

RIAN PHIN

On Dress-Up as Method
By Catalina brown

Long before TikTok outfit videos and digital moodboards, Rian Phin was styling avatars. "I think avatar styling could have been a form of fashion synthesis," they reflect, speaking to me over TikTok Live. "It was processing what was going on culturally. Literally making outfits we saw in music videos. Ashley Simpson, Mariah Carey, Ciara. Whatever was on MTV, we would recreate it."

As a writer, creator, and archivist of Black digital aesthetics, Rian's work often centres on how fashion circulates online, historically, and socially. But in our conversation, it's clear that the roots of their visual thinking go all the way back to digital dress-up games. Platforms like The Palace and Habbo weren't just for fun. They were spaces where fashion, identity, and power were played with seriously, even if no one admitted it at the time.

"People don't realise how much status was coded into those worlds," Rian says. "Even your username. If you had the tag from one of the editing clans, that meant something. It was self-mythology. You were showing people, 'I have power in this community.'"

Status came from access: who had the best-drawn pieces, who could layer, edit, and remix digital clothing with the most finesse. "The cool stuff, the hard-to-draw things. If you were one of the people making those, you had status. That stuff mattered in elementary

school. I think that's when I started to understand what fashion could do."

Today, Rian's daily outfit videos feel like a continuation of that early aesthetic roleplay. Now it's their real body on the line. "It's similar to what I was doing on The Palace," they say. "I have to face the weather, obviously, and the risks of being perceived in public. But sharing outfits online still feels like constructing an avatar. I don't have to post. I choose to. I curate what I show."

That idea of control runs through the conversation: control over representation, over visibility, over taste. When I ask what they'd put a Habbo avatar in today, Rian laughs. "All the ugliest stuff," they say. "The baby Lego shoes, the pineapple hair, the chin set forward. It's a way of saying, 'Deal with it.'" There's power, they argue, in refusing the aesthetic rules that digital spaces often reinforce, especially around beauty and taste. "People love to say what's cringe, the big bobs, the long skirts, and then it becomes a trend later. You can't win, so you might as well wear everything at once."

There's a sharpness beneath the play. A knowing critique of how platforms shape and limit our visual language. But more than anything, Rian is interested in how these constraints can be flipped. "You had a prop bag full of, like, twenty thousand pieces. Of course you could tell any story you wanted. That's what I learned. You can build a character and then change. And then change again."